DRAFT FOR REVIEW — Tropi Q · Article 2 · Content review only, not yet published

HANOI GUIDE · HEAD SPA · TRAVEL TIPS

7 Relaxing Things to Do in Hanoi Near Hoan Kiem Lake

Slow down, breathe, and discover what this part of the city does best.

8 MIN READ · JULY 2026 · TROPIQSPA.COM

Hanoi is exciting — but it can also be overwhelming. After hours of walking through the Old Quarter, navigating busy intersections, and absorbing a city that never quite slows down, many travelers start looking for relaxing things to do in Hanoi that go beyond the next temple or street food stop.

Fortunately, the area around Hoan Kiem Lake offers far more than sightseeing. From quiet lakeside walks at dawn and hidden cafés to a genuine Vietnamese head spa in Hanoi that most guests describe as the highlight of their trip, this part of the city rewards those who take their time.

Here are seven experiences worth slowing down for — all within easy reach of Hoan Kiem Lake.



Head spa treatment at Tropi Q — 7 Tran Phu, Ba Dinh, Hanoi

1. Experience a Traditional Vietnamese Head Spa

TOP RECOMMENDATION

If you could choose only one relaxing experience in Hanoi, a traditional Vietnamese head spa would be difficult to beat.

What is a Vietnamese head spa?

A head spa is a professional scalp and hair treatment — different from a regular massage and very different from a salon visit. The focus is the scalp itself: cleansing it deeply, stimulating blood flow through deliberate massage techniques, and nourishing it with targeted ingredients.

In Vietnam, this practice draws from a long tradition of herbal hair care. Ingredients like *hương nhu* (Vietnamese holy basil), *ngải cứu* (mugwort), *bồ kết* (soapberry), and *vỏ bưởi* (pomelo peel) have been used to care for the scalp for generations. A skilled therapist combines these herbal

ingredients with massage techniques that work across the scalp, neck, and shoulders in one continuous session.

Why travelers keep coming back

For tourists, the appeal is straightforward. A head spa in Hanoi works on several things at once: jet lag, tension built up from travel and long walks, mental fatigue from navigating a new city, and the general need to stop moving for a while.

Unlike a standard massage, a head spa also includes a deep scalp cleanse and nourishing treatment — so you leave feeling genuinely rested, with noticeably healthier hair. Most guests describe it as somewhere between a massage and a meditation session. Many fall asleep during the treatment.

A session typically lasts 60 to 90 minutes. No preparation needed. You simply arrive and lie back.

Where to go: Tropi Q



The head spa room at Tropi Q — designed for full relaxation

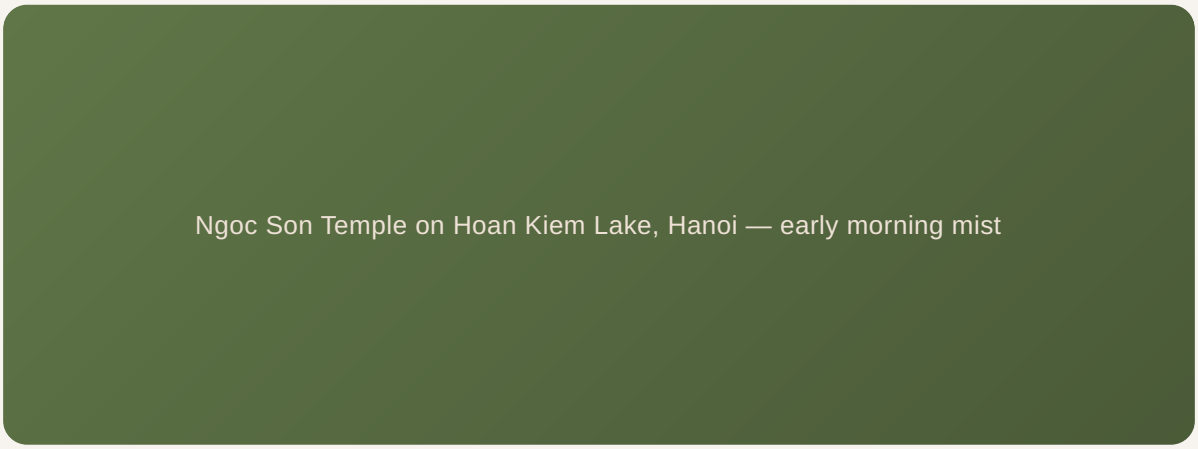
Tropi Q is located at 7 Tran Phu, Ba Dinh — about 10 minutes on foot from Hoan Kiem Lake and a 2-minute walk from Phùng Hưng Train Street. It was built specifically around the Vietnamese herbal head spa experience, with a signature herbal scent blended exclusively for the space, soft ambient lighting, curated music, and therapists trained in scalp techniques not found elsewhere in Vietnam.

The team speaks English and works regularly with international guests. Booking is done via WhatsApp, and sessions are available daily until 8:30pm.

> *If you are looking for a peaceful, genuinely Vietnamese experience after exploring Hanoi, Tropi Q is one of the most recommended stops near Hoan Kiem Lake.*

---

2. Walk Around Hoan Kiem Lake at Sunrise



Ngoc Son Temple on Hoan Kiem Lake, Hanoi — best seen at sunrise

Before the city wakes up, Hoan Kiem Lake belongs to the locals. Between 5:30 and 7:00 in the morning, the lakeside path fills with a quiet rhythm: elderly residents practising tai chi, families walking side

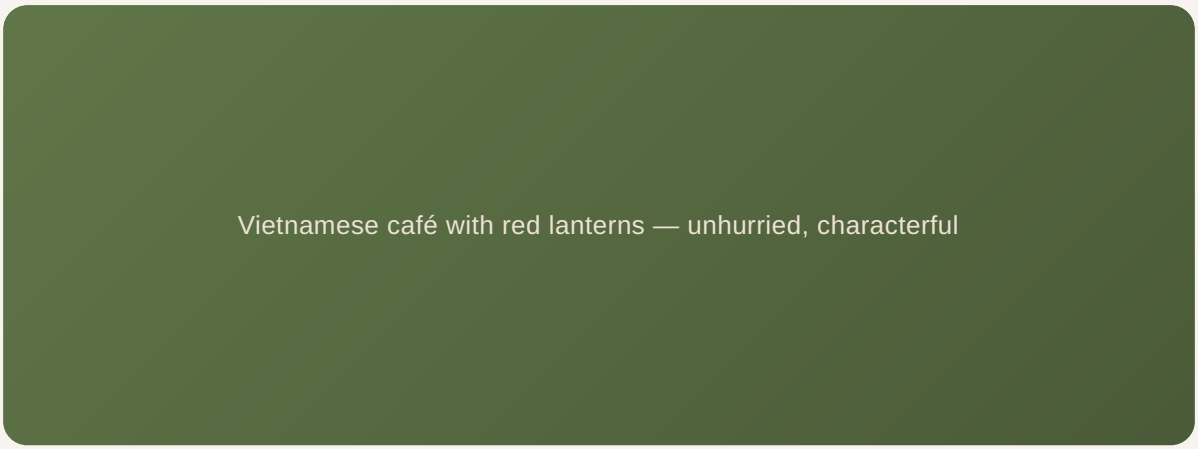
by side, vendors arranging their first trays of the day. The air is cooler, the motorbikes have not yet arrived, and the usual noise is still absent.

The walk around the full lake takes about 20 minutes at an easy pace. The Ngoc Son Temple — sitting on a small island connected to the shore by the red Huc Bridge — is best seen in this early light. The reflection on the calm water is one of those images most visitors who sleep in never get to see.

Even for those who are not naturally early risers, setting an alarm once during your time in Hanoi is worth it.

---

3. Find a Quiet Café and Stay a While



Vietnamese café culture — unhurried, characterful, and worth finding

Hanoi has a coffee culture that rewards the unhurried. Hidden behind the main tourist streets are cafés tucked into courtyard gardens, up narrow staircases to balconies overlooking the rooftops, or inside French colonial-era buildings that have barely changed in decades. These are not places designed for a quick stop.

Egg coffee — *cà phê trứng* — is worth trying at least once. It is a Hanoi original: strong coffee in a small cup, topped with a warm, lightly

sweetened egg cream. It sounds unusual. It tastes like something between a dessert and a drink, and it is difficult to describe to someone who has not had it.

Find a seat with a view, order slowly, and resist the urge to plan your next stop while you are still in this one.

---

4. Visit Hanoi Train Street During the Quiet Hours



Phùng Hưng Train Street, Hanoi — arrive early for the quieter experience

Hanoi Train Street is one of the city's most photographed spots — a narrow lane where the railway track runs so close to the houses that residents must step indoors when a train passes. At peak hours, it is crowded. But arrive on a weekday morning before 10:00, or on a quieter afternoon, and the street shows a different character: locals going about their day, cats asleep on the tracks, shopkeepers arranging goods in doorways just centimetres from the rail.

The train still comes through — check the schedule before you visit. The few minutes before it arrives, when residents calmly move chairs and pots off the tracks, feels entirely, distinctly Hanoi.

Tropi Q is a 2-minute walk from Phùng Hưng Train Street, which makes the two a natural pairing: the tracks in the morning, a head spa a short walk away in the afternoon.

---

5. Try Vietnamese Herbal Tea — Starting with Atiso

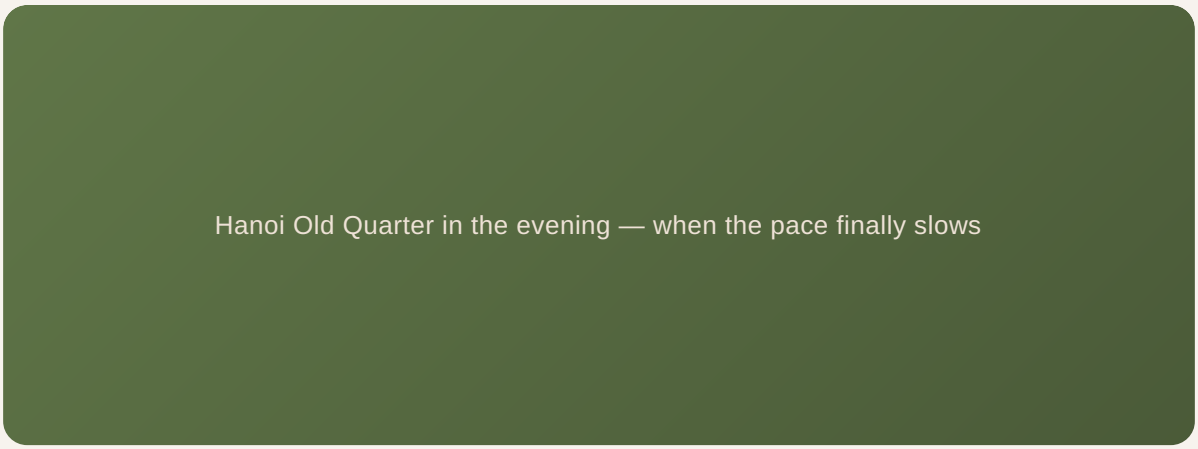
When most travelers think of a break in Hanoi, coffee is the first instinct. But Vietnamese herbal tea is worth discovering on its own terms.

Atiso — artichoke tea — stands out. It is a gentle, slightly earthy drink with a natural sweetness, made from dried artichoke flowers and leaves. It is calming, completely caffeine-free, and far more common in Vietnamese daily life than in tourist cafés. Crucially, it does not interfere with sleep — which makes it an ideal choice in the afternoon or evening, particularly for travelers adjusting to a new time zone.

Atiso is harder to find than it should be — most cafés simply do not serve it. At Tropi Q, guests are offered atiso tea as part of the head spa experience, brewed to a traditional recipe. It is a small detail, but one that reflects the same thinking as the treatment itself: Vietnamese ingredients, used simply, for genuine effect.

---

6. Take a Slow Evening Walk Through the Old Quarter



The Old Quarter in the evening — when the pace finally slows

The Old Quarter of Hanoi has 36 streets, each historically dedicated to a specific trade — silk, paper, tin, bamboo. Many of those trades are still visible today, alongside the small restaurants, cafés, and family shops that have filled in around them.

In the evening, when the temperature drops and the light softens, Hanoi Old Quarter becomes easier to absorb. The streets are still busy, but the pace shifts. Hidden side streets barely wide enough for two people open into quiet courtyards or small restaurants with plastic stools on the pavement.

Take a route without a destination. Turn down alleys that look interesting. Stop when something catches your attention. This is the part of Hanoi that rewards wandering more than any itinerary can plan for.

---

7. Watch Sunset From the Lake

Hoan Kiem Lake in the late afternoon feels different from every other time of day. The light on the water shifts from sharp to golden. Families

return for an evening walk, street food appears along the paths, and the Turtle Tower in the middle of the lake catches the last of the light before the sky changes color.

Local life returns to the edges of the water in a way that feels entirely natural — unhurried, unperformed, simply there. Find a bench or a low wall near the water. No agenda required. This is a good place to end a day that has moved at a human pace.

Suggested relaxing half-day itinerary

Everything within 15 minutes on foot from Hoan Kiem Lake.

TIME	ACTIVITY
8:00	Walk around Hoan Kiem Lake
9:00	Vietnamese coffee at a hidden café
10:30	Visit Hanoi Train Street
12:00	Lunch near the Old Quarter
14:00	Head spa at Tropi Q (7 Tran Phu, Ba Dinh)
16:00	Browse the Old Quarter streets
Sunset	Return to Hoan Kiem Lake

Nothing in this itinerary requires a taxi. Everything is within 15 minutes on foot from Hoan Kiem Lake.

Frequently asked questions

Is Hanoi a good city for relaxation travel?

Hanoi has a long tradition of massage, herbal therapy, and tea culture — practices that are part of everyday Vietnamese life rather than reserved for tourists. The area around Hoan Kiem Lake and the Old Quarter offers a range of genuinely local relaxation experiences at accessible prices.

What is the most relaxing thing to do in Hanoi?

For physical rest after travel, a traditional Vietnamese head spa combines scalp massage, herbal treatment, and deep relaxation in a single session. For mental calm, an early morning walk around Hoan Kiem Lake or a slow afternoon in a quiet café are equally restorative. Both work well in combination.

Where can I find a head spa near Hoan Kiem Lake?

Tropi Q is located at 7 Tran Phu, Ba Dinh, Hanoi — approximately 10 minutes on foot from Hoan Kiem Lake and a 2-minute walk from Phùng Hưng Train Street. It specialises in Vietnamese herbal head spa treatments and accepts bookings via WhatsApp: 0333 892 329.

How long does a Vietnamese head spa take?

A standard session lasts 60 to 90 minutes and includes a scalp consultation, herbal cleanse, therapeutic massage targeting the scalp, neck and shoulders, and a nourishing treatment. Some guests add a foot spa, which extends the session accordingly.

Is a head spa worth it for tourists visiting Hanoi?

For most travelers — particularly those dealing with jet lag, muscle tension from long walks, or general travel fatigue — a head spa offers a specific kind of rest that sightseeing and standard massage do not. The combination of herbal ingredients, scalp care, and therapeutic massage tends to leave guests feeling noticeably different afterward.

RELATED READING

What Is a Head Spa? Everything You Need to Know →

Head Spa Services at Tropi Q →

Plan a relaxing day in Hanoi

Combine a morning walk around Hoan Kiem Lake with an authentic Vietnamese herbal head spa a short walk away. A natural way to recharge before continuing your journey through the city.

● 7 Tran Phu, Ba Dinh, Hanoi (2-min walk from Phùng Hưng Train Street) · Open daily until 8:30pm

Book a session

Tropi Q

● 7 Tran Phu, Ba Dinh, Hanoi (2-min walk from Phùng Hưng Train Street)

Open daily · Last booking 8:30pm · WhatsApp: WhatsApp: 0333 892 329